

DEPARTMENT OF NATURAL RESOURCES & ENVIRONMENTAL DESIGN • NC A&T

Executive Speaking Notes & Strategic Talking Points

Meeting with Department Chair Dr. Niroj Aryal & Program Coordinator Dallas Bretzman

DATE & TIME

Tuesday, Sept 8, 2026

PROPOSAL TRACK

USDA NIFA 1890 CBG
(\$750k Integrated)

IMMEDIATE DEADLINE

NOI Due Wed, Sept 9
(Tomorrow)

LEAD PI

W. Chris Harrison, MLA,
ASLA

1. CORE MEETING OBJECTIVE

HIGH LEVEL

The Goal: Reassure Dr. Aryal that this proposal represents an effortless **\$750,000 institutional win** for NRED that brings in funded Graduate Assistants and college visibility, while completely **releasing Dallas from any workload or curriculum anxiety**. Lock in Dr. Aryal's approval to lodge the 1-page non-binding NOI placeholder by Wednesday, Sept 9.

2. THE 60-SECOND OPENING (DISARM & DE-ESCALATE)

CRITICAL FIRST MOVE

SCRIPTED OPENING STATEMENT:

"Dr. Aryal, before we jump into details, I want to say that Dallas is doing a fantastic job stewarding the new BSLA curriculum. Launching a revised catalog four weeks ago is a heavy lift, and protecting the stability of our studio classes is the right instinct. I 100% support her keeping her full focus there."

• **Why it works:** Diffuses all adversarial tension immediately. Dallas cannot attack someone who is praising her in front of her supervisor.

3. FIVE ESSENTIAL TALKING POINTS

CORE SCRIPT

POINT 1 Zero Syllabus or Catalog Burden (No Mandated Changes)

"I want to clear up a major misconception: this grant does **not** alter our approved course catalog, syllabi, or LAAB accreditation in any way. It is strictly an **optional experiential enrichment resource**—providing extracurricular student workshops, software access, and drone/sensor tools that faculty can draw from only if they choose. If an instructor doesn't want to touch it, they don't have to."

- *Eliminates Dallas's fear that unapproved catalog changes or accreditation risks are being imposed.*

POINT 2 Dallas is 100% Off the Hook (Zero Labor for Her)

"Dallas has a full plate with coordinator duties. Dallas, I want to make sure you know: **you have zero obligation on this grant**. You do not need to serve as Co-PI, do any reporting, or manage technology. That initial placeholder was strictly a courtesy for future summer support if you wanted it. Our multi-college team handles 100% of the administration."

- *Dallas opposed this because she feared extra work. Removing the duty evaporates her motivation to resist.*

POINT 3 The Grant Directly Funds the Technical Labor (2 GRAs + 2 UGAs)

"Dallas raised a fair question about technical maintenance and faculty expertise. But that's exactly why the budget is structured to fund **2 Graduate Research Assistants (\$16k/yr stipends) and 2 Paid Undergraduate Assistants (\$4k/yr)**. These funded students manage the hardware, troubleshoot software, and run student tutorials. It brings over **\$120,000 directly into student financial support** for NRED."

- *Chairs love funded Graduate Assistant lines. It solves the technical labor problem without faculty effort.*

POINT 4 The \$750,000 Integrated Project Upgrade & Powerhouse Coalition

"The response across CAES and CoST has been overwhelmingly positive:

- **Dr. Omon Isikhuemhen** joined and recommended we step up to the **\$750k Integrated Track (Teaching + Research)**, pairing his forest mycology research with our spatial digital twins.
- **Dr. Leila Hashemi Beni** (Director, GEMS Institute, CoST) is leading remote sensing and LiDAR.
- **Dr. Porché Spence** is leading environmental studies and water/soil conservation.
- **Charlie Hopper** is anchoring field demonstration at the Small Farm Research & Innovation Center (SFRIC)."

• *Shows Dr. Aryal that walking away now means turning down \$750k and alienating prominent senior colleagues across two colleges.*

POINT 5 Charlie Hopper's Pivot: Framing as "Environmental Planning & Living Landscapes"

"As Charlie Hopper wisely noted, the broader college is ready to move on these technologies. To completely protect the BSLA brand, we are framing the primary title as **Environmental Planning, Digital Agroforestry, and Living Landscapes**. LA and Environmental Studies students gain all the stipends, credentials, and tools, while the BSLA program remains fully autonomous."

• *Completely sidesteps the internal LA curriculum dispute and aligns with college-wide strategic priorities.*

4. QUICK OBJECTION & REBUTTAL MATRIX

HANDLING PUSHBACK

IF DALLAS OR ARYAL SAYS...	YOUR STRATEGIC RESPONSE
"Our new BSLA curriculum just started 4 weeks ago; it's too early."	"Exactly why this is co-curricular enrichment, not a catalog revision. It doesn't touch the syllabus, but brings \$750k in lab resources that students can use immediately."
"Our faculty don't have the technical expertise to teach this."	"Core faculty don't have to teach it. The grant funds 2 GRAs and 2 UGAs specifically to run tutorials, field sensors, and drone workflows."
"We should wait a year or two until we have assessment baselines."	"In federal funding cycles, waiting two years forfeits \$750k. The grant itself funds the baseline assessment tools and student tracking we need for future accreditations."
"This seems like a lot of work right now before Wednesday."	"The Wednesday NOI is just a 1-page non-binding placeholder to keep NC A&T eligible. I have already drafted it; no one else has to write a single word."

5. COMMITTED MULTI-COLLEGE COALITION

UNANIMOUS SUPPORT

Dr. Leila Hashemi Beni Director, GEMS Institute (CoST) • Co-PI / LiDAR & UAV Remote Sensing	Dr. Omon Isikhuemhen Professor, Plant & Soil Sciences (CAES) • Co-PI / \$750k Integrated Research Lead	Dr. Porché L. Spence Assistant Professor, Env. Studies (NRED) • Co-PI / Soil Health & NRCS Credentialing
Momtanu Chakraborty Biological Engineering / Canvas Lead • Co-PI / Pix4D & Module Dissemination	Charles Hopper Director, SFRIC • Key Personnel / Field Living Laboratory	W. Chris Harrison Assistant Professor, LA (NRED) • Project Director / Lead PI

6. THE CLOSING MOTION FOR DR. ARYAL

ACTION ITEM

CLOSING STATEMENT TO DR. ARYAL:

"Dr. Aryal, Wednesday's 1-page NOI is simply an internal placeholder so NC A&T doesn't forfeit eligibility for this \$750k track. It commits us to nothing binding. Let's lodge the placeholder with you tomorrow, keep Dallas completely unburdened, and let our cross-college team refine the research scope with Dr. Omon and Dr. Leila ahead of the September 28 campus deadline."

North Carolina Agricultural and Technical State University • College of Agriculture and Environmental Sciences
Department of Natural Resources and Environmental Design • Strategic Research & Grants Initiative